

officer of a Houston oil company when his work life tore him apart. He took a leave of absence, went to Europe with his family, and had a ball. Once back in Houston, he added up what he had spent and backed into the \$50-a-Day Rule. He went to his old boss and resigned.

For the first few months of retirement Sam got reacquainted with old Houston friends. He played golf, relaxed by the pool in his backyard, read Kierkegaard, and painted still lifes in his small studio behind the garage. Sam followed the rule:

Fill your new days with old activities

Three months into his retirement, Sam made his first mistake. He went back to work as a consultant for his old company. Sam told me about it later.

“The chairman called me at home and insisted that I help him with a first-ever strategic plan. He was very flattering. ‘I need someone independent, from the outside, but who knows the company. You’ve got the experience, the vision, you’re uniquely qualified, blah, blah, blah.’ I fell for it.

“It turned out to be a disaster. Others on the project saw me as an interloper. They were polite but ignored my ideas. I could have gone to the chairman for support, but I wasn’t up for a fight. I figured it was their company, they could do what they wanted.

“It got worse and worse. I was half-working, half-retired, and unhappy in both. I could feel myself becoming tense and irritable for the first time since retiring. But I saw no graceful way out of the project before it was finished. That took six months, perhaps the worst six months of my retired life.

“At least it won’t happen again,” Sam concluded ruefully. “The chairman and staff over there hate me now.”

Sam’s experience is worth a rule:

Make a clean break
